

How to Find an Affordable Individual Health Policy

Unfortunately, locating a reasonably priced individual health insurance policy isn't easy. Here are some tips that may help you in your search.

- **Search online for quotes.** Start shopping for online health insurance quotes at eHealthInsurance (www.ehealthinsurance.com), which lets you compare policies from many insurance companies. If you find a policy that's a good fit, you can then apply right on the site. But before you sign up, visit NetQuote (www.netquote.com), which can put you in touch with agents affiliated with some of the nation's largest health insurers. Tell them about the best deal you found online and ask if they can beat it.
- **Try Blue Cross and Blue Shield.** They're the largest managed care and indemnity providers in the United States but they don't accept everyone who applies. You can contact your local Blue Cross and Blue Shield company or visit the website (www.bcbs.com) to find out about eligibility requirements and rates.
- **Contact your state insurance department.** If you have a preexisting condition that makes it difficult for you to get insurance, get in touch with your state insurance department and ask if it sponsors any "high-risk" insurance policies. Most do. If yours doesn't, ask if it may be able to point you toward a private insurer that does. And even if you're healthy, check the website of your state's insurance department to see if you're eligible for any special deals.
- **Ask about special deals for people in good health.** Some insurers and HMOs (as well as your state's insurance department) offer discounts to people who can show they're in great shape. If that sounds like you, ask the agent whether you can get one.
- **As a last resort, consider catastrophic (also known as "high-deductible") coverage.** If you have very little money